

Developing a culture of respecting difference with young children, their families and communities in Northern Ireland



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Introduction

This chapter will describe how Early Years - the organisation for young children in Northern Ireland pioneered a culture of respect for difference with young children, their teachers and parents against the backdrop of a deeply divided society, scarred and traumatised by 30 years of conflict. The chapter will describe how, with support from a range of stakeholders, the organisation developed the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Curriculum (MIFC) and implemented this new approach across the Early Years sector in Northern Ireland, Ireland and beyond. The approach has been subjected to rigorous independent research and evaluation, including a large random control trial and a range of qualitative evaluations. The chapter will describe how using evidence helped influence and change early education policy in Northern Ireland. It will also highlight the challenges of implementation within a difficult political, policy and practice environment which includes the impact of Brexit, COVID, austerity and many periods of political uncertainty in Northern Ireland. The chapter will end with a summary of the organisation's hopes and plans for the future.

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"All conflict is about difference, whether the difference is race, religion or nationality. Difference is an accident of birth and therefore should never be a source of hatred or conflict. The answer to difference is to respect it. Therein lies a most fundamental principle of peace—respect for diversity"

(John Hume Nobel Laureate Speech, 1998)

"Too long a sacrifice, can make a stone of the heart".

(W.B. Yeats)

Abstract

This chapter will describe how Early Years - the organisation for young children in Northern Ireland, pioneered a culture of respect for difference with young children, their teachers and parents against the backdrop of a deeply divided society, scarred and traumatised by 30 years of conflict. The chapter will describe how with support from a range of stakeholders, the organisation developed the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Curriculum (MIFC) and implemented this new approach across the Early Years sector in Northern Ireland, Ireland and beyond. The approach has been subjected to rigorous independent research and evaluation, including a large random control trial and a range of qualitative evaluations. The chapter will describe how using evidence helped influence and change early education policy in Northern Ireland. The chapter will also highlight the challenges of implementation within a difficult political, policy and practice environment that includes the impact of Brexit, COVID, austerity and many periods of political uncertainty in Northern Ireland. The chapter will end with a summary of the organisation's hopes and plans for the future.

Background

Early Years - the organisation for young children (formerly known as NIPPA), was founded in 1965, with the aim of developing community-led preschool services across Northern Ireland. From the beginning, and specifically after the outbreak of conflict in 1969, the organisation was committed to a cross-community, non-sectarian approach, ensuring that the two main traditions at the time, Catholics and Protestants, had an opportunity for children to come together to play, and for parents to get to know each other through the development of community-led and managed services.

Since the 1970's there has been a growth in cross-community-led preschool and parent and toddler groups, seeing the development of such services in every small parish across Northern Ireland. Against the backdrop of "The Troubles" (the Northern Ireland conflict 1969-1994), these services provided a safe space for parents and children across the religious divide to get to know one another, despite the horror that was unfolding around them.

After the ceasefires in 1994, and with investment by the European Union in a Special Support Programme for Peace and Reconciliation (SEUPB, 2001), investment in early years was seen as one of the key vehicles for building the peace in Northern Ireland and the Southern Border counties in Republic of Ireland. This investment in young children and their families by the European Union continues to the present day and is an important recognition of the contribution of Early Childhood Programmes to sustainable peace and development.

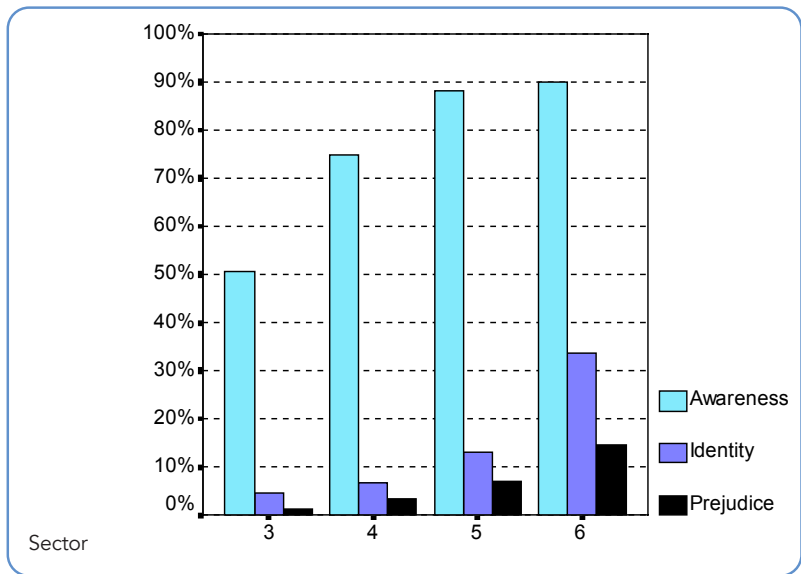
A Challenge to the sector

The signing of the 1998 Good Friday/Belfast Agreement was a significant step forward in terms of taking the gun out of Irish politics. The Nationalist/Republican, Unionist /Loyalist Political parties and the paramilitaries agreed a complex and ambiguous set of arrangements that supported consensual, cross-community governance arrangements. There were three

main strands to the agreement: the internal strand, relating to Northern Ireland, the east-west strand relating to the arrangements with the rest of the UK, and the north-south strand relating to arrangements with Ireland. The Good Friday agreement, with a focus on rights, social justice and reconciliation, presented a positive policy environment for the development of services for young children.

Given the long history of investment in high-quality, non-sectarian, evidence-informed early childhood services, Early Years was confident that services for young children could play an ever-increasing role in the quest for social cohesion and peacebuilding. However, in 2001 the publication of the research "Too Young to Notice?" (Connolly, 2002) was a wakeup call for the sector. The research presented the harsh reality that children, as young as three, in Northern Ireland were developing negative, prejudicial attitudes toward others and by the age of six, these attitudes were becoming embedded. The research also challenged prevailing views at the time, that young children were too young to notice the sectarian divisions that surrounded them.

Table 1. Too Young to Notice? A challenge for the Early Years



A new approach

The research findings were a catalyst for the organisation to rethink its approach to dealing with issues of race, religion, ethnicity and identity. The organisation made the decision to take an explicit, intentional approach, from being a non-sectarian, to becoming an anti-sectarian organisation, and looked for help from outside to support a complete rethink of how services for young children and their families were delivered in a divided society.

Around this time the organisation was approached by the Peace Initiatives Institute (PII) from Colorado, U.S.A. who wanted to contribute to the peacebuilding activities that were taking place at the time. PII facilitated the development of a multi-level stakeholder partnership, including media, academia, education partners and policymakers that worked collaboratively with Early Years to develop a new early years' programme. The programme became known as the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme. The programme aimed to develop a 'respecting difference' culture that celebrated the variety of differences in Northern Ireland society. While ethnic and religious differences had been at the heart of the conflict, there was a recognition of the need to celebrate other emerging differences on the basis of

race, disability, gender and also promote an anti-bullying, respectful culture that would underpin relationships between children, parents, teachers and the wider community. It is important to recognise the critical role that PII played in supporting change in Northern Ireland. They were critical in encouraging the use of media as part of any new programme development. They were also the first to the table in providing funding for programme development.

Without their initial seed funding, the multi-million-pound investment that followed may never have been realised. Another key and early funder at the time was the International Fund for Ireland, which funded the implementation of the programme in Northern Ireland and in all the southern border counties in the Republic of Ireland. The support from the International Fund for Ireland provided significant visibility and credibility to the MIFC programme and Early Years as an organisation.

During the period 2003-2010, Early Years, supported by the multi-agency stakeholder group and with wide consultation and participation from young children, parents, preschool teachers and local community activists, developed, piloted, implemented and evaluated the MIFC.

Programme Components

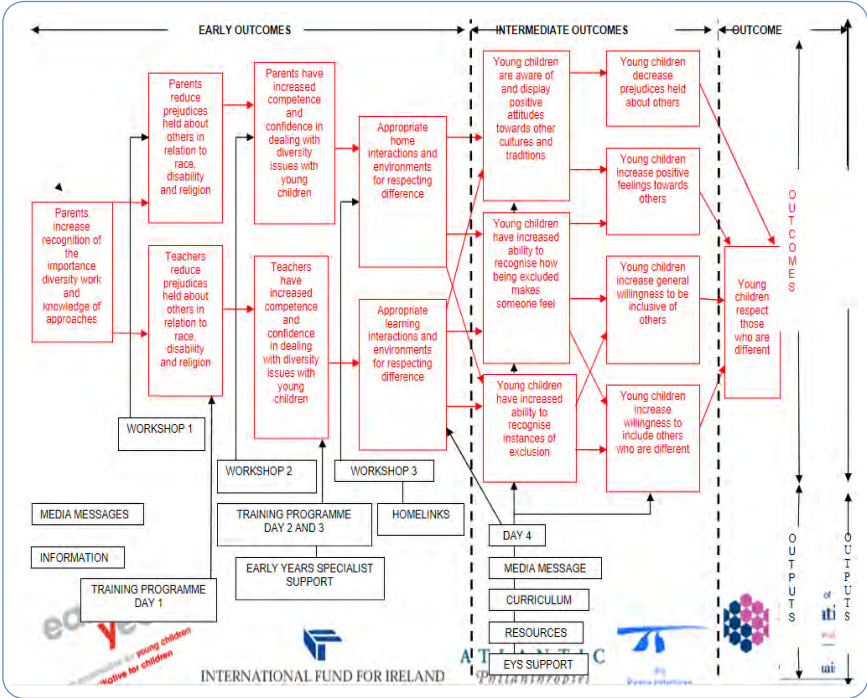
The new programme had several distinct components:

- The development of five new persona characters representing religious, physical disability, ethnic and race differences. These characters were developed as a result of consultation with young children, their parents and the wider community. The characters were named and provided with a specific community background representing difference within a Northern Ireland context.
- The development of five cartoon media messages reflecting instances of exclusion and inclusion. The media messages were played initially on National Television for three weeks at a time, three times per year. They were watched by children on their own and by parents and children together. The use of the media was critical in terms of creating community ownership for the programme.
- The development of a new curriculum and Service Design Manual, aimed at supporting preschool teachers to implement a new respecting difference approach in a culturally and contextually appropriate manner

- The development of new training programmes for preschool teachers and parents that was based on reflective techniques, helping teachers and parents reflect on their earliest experience of difference. This supported them to understand and respect the "other" within a Northern Ireland context and develop techniques and strategies to implement the programme within the classroom and home environment.
- The development of a range of new resources reflecting the cultural, religious, sporting and musical traditions within a divided society
- The development of capacity-building activities for management committees and school leaders so that they could support the development of anti-sectarian policies and strategies within their local services
- The support of an Early Years Specialist providing five hours per month of external mentoring to support early childhood services in implementing the programme to fidelity.

The development of the programme was influenced by the need to move away from a superficial approach to dealing with religious, race and ethnic issues. Traditionally in Northern Ireland early childhood programmes adopted a neutral approach to such issues, which in fact meant they were often ignored. We wanted to move away from approaches that supported limited contact for children from different religious, ethnic and socio-economic backgrounds and were keen to create deep, meaningful and prolonged daily experiences for children, teachers and families. We were influenced by theorists on social cohesion that stressed the importance of building trust and respect for each other and a sense of belonging. Reference (Durkheim, Larsen, Putnam, Derman-Sparks, Pettigrew and Tropp).

Table 2. Early Years Theory of Change Mode



The programme was initially targeted for three- to five-year-old children, their parents and preschool teachers in Northern Ireland and the southern Border counties of the Republic of Ireland. As the programme developed, it was expanded for two to eight year-olds in full daycare settings and afterschool facilities. The programme was delivered every day in preschool settings over the course of the preschool year from September to the end of June.

Prior to implementation of the programme, staff were provided with three days of experiential training and additionally, with a Service Design Manual to support the daily delivery of the programme, and to support them in engaging with parents. The Service Design Manual encouraged integration of the MIFC with the national preschool curriculum. Parents were provided with termly parent workshops that introduced them to the new programme, encouraged them to reflect on their own experiences of difference and division and supported them with resources to implement the programme in the home environment.

Underpinning the development of the Programme was a Theory of Change/ Logical Framework approach that was developed during the pilot implementation phase.

Doing No Harm: a commitment to ongoing research and evaluation

Early Years was introducing a new approach within the Northern Ireland preschool curriculum, an approach that took an intentional, anti-sectarian, contextually appropriate focus to the issues that had caused enormous division within Northern Ireland society. Sport, music, cultural activities and flags were often symbols of division across Northern Ireland society. Yet, the new approach intentionally used these symbols of division to create a culture of respecting and understanding differences.

It was important therefore that evidence ensured that the approach was not further exacerbating the situation and creating even further divisions. A small pilot evaluation of the approach in 2003, involving ten preschool groups, five in the control group and 15 in the experimental group, was critical in spurring us on to continue with the development and implementation of the MIFC.

Table 3. Pilot Programme Results 2003. Do no harm.

- Quasi experimental design with 10 preschool settings
- Five received the programme, five were in a control group
- Measured children’s attitudes before and after the programme
- Ability to understand how being excluded made someone feel
- Ability to recognise instances of exclusion
- Willingness to play with others who were different

Between 2003 and 2010 Early Years continued to develop and implement the MIFC programme across the Early Years sector in Northern Ireland and the Border Counties in the Republic of Ireland. Each year over this period we worked with approximately 50 preschool settings, involving approximately 1000 children and their families in Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland. With the support of an Early Years Specialist, staff from the settings were trained, provided with a Service Design Manual and a new set of resources, including the five persona characters. Settings were supported to implement the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme on a daily basis and engage in regular parent support workshops so that the programme could be implemented by parents in the home environment. The five cartoon messages were shown on National Television for three weeks at a time, three times per year. The use of the media was an important strategy to create broad community ownership for the programme and became a useful tool for parents/grandparents to talk about the programme at home.

In 2010 with funding from the Atlantic Philanthropies, Early Years were able to commission Queens University Belfast, Stranmillis University College and the National Children’s Bureau (Northern Ireland) to carry out a large random control trial. The research involved 80 preschool groups, 1600 children and parents in Northern Ireland and Republic of Ireland, coupled with several qualitative case studies. The results were a positive indication that the MIFC programme was having a significant impact in supporting young children’s social and emotional development and creating a culture of inclusion and respecting difference.

Table 4. Random Control Trial Results (2010) for children
Key findings (with effect sizes):

- Increased socio-emotional development (+.34 to +.61).
- Increased cultural awareness (+.38 to +.7).
- Increased desire to join in with cultural activities (+.17 to +.27).
- Effects found are those above and beyond the effects associated with normal preschool provision.
- Effects were the same regardless of the characteristics of the children.
- Effects were the same regardless of the characteristics of the settings delivering the Media Initiative.

Table 5. Random Control Trial. Results for Teachers and Parents

Some potentially encouraging signs found re:

- Increased awareness of the need to do diversity work with young children.
- Increased confidence in their own ability to do this.
- However, for methodological reasons, none of these encouraging signs can be trusted without further research.

Table 6. Qualitative Case Studies. Perspectives of Key Stakeholders

- Practitioners valued the training, ongoing specialist support, curriculum and resources; felt the programme impacted positively on their own skills and confidence.
- Parents welcomed the programme; felt it presented an important opportunity for their children to learn about diversity and develop respect for others.
- Children were observed to find the resources and activities appealing; activities provided an important safe space for them to explore diversity issues.

Table 7. Qualitative Case Studies: Key Drivers of Successful Implementation

- Training for practitioners.
- Ongoing advice and support from Early Years Specialists.
- Variety and quality of resources and their integration across all elements of the setting's activities.
- Working effectively with parents.
- Effective and committed leadership within settings.

(Connolly, 2010)

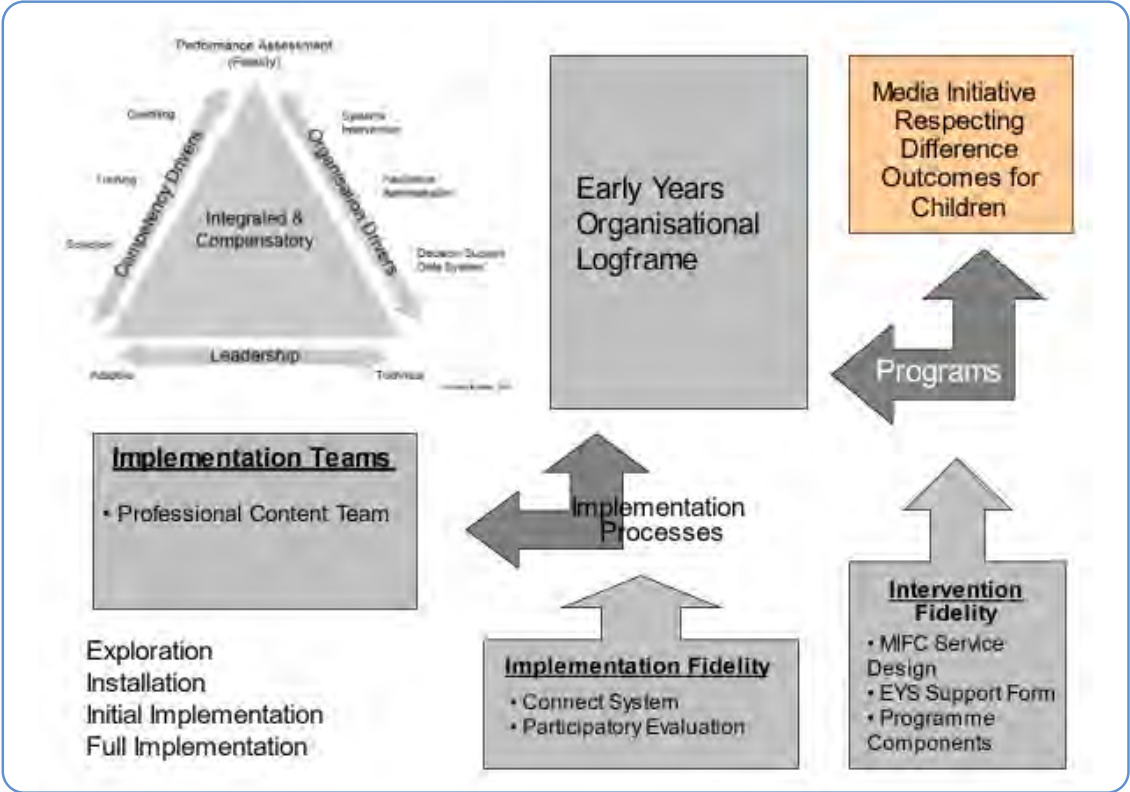
The positive results from the Random Control Trial and the Qualitative Case studies brought both political and funder attention to the innovative approach being implemented by Early Years. Over the next decade, investment for implementation and going to scale was provided by the Department of Education in Northern Ireland, the Children's Commission in Northern Ireland and the Office of the Ombudsman for Children in Ireland, the International Fund for Ireland, the European Union and Atlantic Philanthropies.

Implementation and Going to Scale

From 2010 to date, Early Years has developed a systematic approach to both scaling up and implementation. This approach was adapted from the work of Richard Kohl in his book "Learning and Leading for Large Scale Change" (Kohl, 2007) and also from the "International and Irish Implementation Science Organisations".

The approach involved developing a Scaling Up strategy, establishing a cross cutting internal Implementation Team led by the Chief Executive Officer. Externally, the organisation developed a detailed Advocacy and sensitisation strategy to convince key stakeholders to resource and support implementation and provide political, financial and institutional sustainability. It was important that the organisation could show the cost of the programme per beneficiary and the efficiency of such a programme in supporting a culture of peace. The support from key stakeholders such as the Education and Training Inspectorate was critical in ensuring credibility for the programme within the preschool curriculum. The organisation also developed a robust system for monitoring fidelity, adaptation and impact on outcomes, as the approach expanded across Ireland and globally. It is important to note that it took 10 years for the full implementation of the Programme.

Table 8. An implementation Strategy



Since its inception, the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme has been adapted and implemented in a range of local and global contexts. The programme has been successfully implemented and evaluated in the border counties in the Republic of Ireland, across Serbia, Croatia, Macedonia, Albania, Montenegro and Kosovo - and recently in Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan. It is hoped that the programme will be implemented in Palestine, Israel and Colombia in the near future.

The Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme has also been a significant component in the new Shared Education Programme in Northern Ireland/Republic of Ireland, through the Sharing from the Start Project, funded by the European Union and the Departments of Education in both Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland.

The EU PEACE IV Programme aims 'To reinforce progress towards a peaceful and stable society through the promotion of reconciliation amongst all communities across Northern Ireland and the Border Region of Ireland'. Shared Education is one of four Specific Objectives of PEACE IV.

Currently in Northern Ireland, the majority of children are educated separately and 30% of schools have either no catholic, or no protestant pupils. The Mainstreaming Shared Education Strategy, sponsored by the Department of Education in Northern Ireland, aims to ensure that Shared Education is embedded in partnership-working across religious and socio-economic divides, delivers educational benefits, and promotes a culture of inclusivity, respect and mutual understanding, contributing to community cohesion and good relations.

Early Years has undertaken extensive partnership work in developing and delivering cross border shared education initiatives under the Peace IV Sharing from the Start Initiative. The work engaged with 120 preschool settings, 13,800 children and 270 educators to deliver meaningful, purposeful, and sustained activity to preschool children, their parents and teachers across the eligible areas.

An independent evaluation reported: (McCarthy, 2022)

Table 9.

- 94% of respondents ‘strongly agreed’ (48%) or ‘agreed’ (46%) that Shared Education has led to improved educational outcomes for participating children.
- 91% of respondents agreed children’s communication skills had improved.
- 97% of respondents ‘strongly agreed’ (43%) or ‘agreed’ (54%) that the funding enhanced teaching and learning.
- 96% of respondents agreed that Shared Education had fostered cross-community co-operation.
- 94% of respondents agreed that their professional teaching skills and knowledge has improved due to their involvement in the Sharing From The Start Programme.

The Media Initiative Respecting Difference Curriculum was the key methodology used in supporting preschool settings implement the Sharing from the Start Shared Education Programme.

Conclusions and hopes for the future

The Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme has been successfully delivered in Northern Ireland for the past 20 years. The successful implementation and ongoing development of the Programme has been possible because of the commitment and dedication of the countless Early Years staff working in community and statutory settings across the region. Despite many challenges they are at the forefront in developing and implementing an innovative approach to quality pre-school services that support social cohesion and reconciliation.

There have been many challenges over the years, mainly to do with uncertainty of funding mechanisms to ensure sustainability of the approach. The support from the European Union, through the Special European Programmes Body has been one constant source of support during the past 20 years. Without this, the programme would not have been able to implement and scale up. This type of long-term funding was a critical success factor.

As we write this chapter, at the end of the early months of 2023, the Northern Ireland Assembly has been collapsed for almost 12 months and indeed, since the Good Friday Agreement, the Assembly and Executive, the critical elements of Strand one of the Agreement, in terms of the internal relations within Northern Ireland, have only operated for approximately one third of the time that it could have. Many of the hopes and aspirations of the period between 1994 ceasefires, the signing of the Good Friday Agreement and the early days of the first power sharing Executive, have lost their optimism and sense of hope. The two main political parties who were the choreographers for the Good Friday Agreement - the Social Democratic and Labour Party, and the Ulster Unionist Party - are now minority political parties with politics being dominated by the Democratic Unionist Party and Sinn Fein. There has also been a significant shift to the middle ground, with

over 14% of the voting population supporting the Alliance Party in the May 2023 elections. Many of the Alliance voters are young voters in the 18-35 age group.

The decision by the UK Government to leave the European Union in the BREXIT Referendum of 2016, even though most voters in Northern Ireland voted to remain within Europe, has further damaged internal relations in Northern Ireland and has propelled the discussions about a possible United Ireland Referendum to a more central stage than it was even a decade ago.

The COVID pandemic, the austerity policies of the Conservative Party in UK, and the war in Ukraine have had a devastating effect on the cost of living and poverty levels in Northern Ireland. Children especially have borne the brunt, with ever increasing levels of child poverty and devastating cuts in public expenditure to services for children.

Yet, as we look back over the past 25 years since the signing of the Good Friday agreement, there have been many positive developments. As always, people are ahead of politicians, and parents, in particular, want a different life experience for their children. Parents are pushing the agenda in Shared and Integrated Education. The Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme has certainly been one of the significant drivers supporting parents' ability and emotional readiness to advocate for such a significant shift in Educational Policy.

The Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme is well embedded within the early year's curriculum. This has not happened overnight and is the result of dedicated commitment to implementation, evaluation and advocacy.

The organisation is looking forward to being involved in the new Special Support Programme for Peace and Reconciliation, Peace Plus Programme and further embedding Shared Education across Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland.

At an international level, the organisation is keen to see further expansion of the Media Initiative Respecting Difference Programme in areas emerging from conflict.

We are committed to supporting the delivery of the Sustainable Development Goals 2015-2030 (Doyle, 2014) and see our work as making an important contribution to the achievement of SDG Goal 4, Quality Education and SDG Goal 16 Peace and Prosperity. We look forward to continuing our international partnerships and collaborative efforts to make these goals a reality.

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